Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are things that link themselves to a colour almost by themselves. **Nobody is born with them**, and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are taken from three places. From the body, from culture and from what we have lived through.

From the body

Yellow is the colour of the sun and of day, and also the lightest of the colours we see. That is exactly why the eye catches it before others, and why it is used everywhere something should draw attention. **Yellow says: Here is light and something is happening.** At the same time, though, it is so bright that it is hard to look at for long, especially large areas.

From culture

In Europe, Canada and the USA yellow is most often linked with **joy**, humour and spontaneity. Alongside that it also carries less pleasant meanings. **Envy**, hypocrisy, greed and in the USA cowardice. **In China and elsewhere in Asia it is on the contrary the colour of emperors, wisdom and harmony. The same colour can thus mean glory and shame. It depends on where we grew up.** We will look at this in more detail in the section on cultures.

From what you have lived

A yellow umbrella from childhood, a kitchen at grandmother's, a yellow marker from school, a hospital glove, a yellow note with a task. **These memories decide the most.** Two women can look at the same yellow and **one feels joy, the other stress** from having to get everything done all the time.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is actually “yellow” and what is your story about it.

Stories

Yellow has a few interesting stories. Some of them are worth untangling, because they show **where the colour ends and where we begin**, we and our brain.

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A word related to gold

The English word yellow comes from Old English geolu and shares a root with the words gold and yell (a shout). The oldest known record is from around the year 700. Yellow and gold are thus related in language. What shines golden got a name similar to what shouts.

The yellow card and the traffic light

The referee Ken Aston devised the yellow and red card after the traffic light. Yellow means caution, red means stop. They were first used at the 1970 World Cup in Mexico. The idea reportedly came from unclear communication at the quarter-final in 1966. **Yellow says: You may still, but we have noticed you.**

The yellow school bus

In 1939 Professor Frank Cyr called a conference at Columbia University to unify standards for school buses. From shades ranging from lemon to orange-red three yellows were selected and finally a golden yellow, because it is most visible in the morning and towards evening.

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